Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: 08/02/2026	**Entry: #1 - Activity: Document an incident with an incident handler's journal**
Description	A small health clinic experienced a security incident on Tuesday at 9 am, severely disrupting their business operations. This incident occurred in two phases: 1. **Detection and Analysis:** The scenario outlines how the organisation first detected the ransomware incident. For the analysis step, the organisation contacted several organisations for technical assistance. 2. **Containment, Eradication, and Recovery:** The scenario details some steps that the organisation took to contain the incident. For example, the company shut down their computer systems. However, since they could not work to eradicate and recover from the incident alone, they contacted several other organisations for assistance.
Tool(s) used	**None**
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who:** Organised group of unethical hackers

	• **What:** A ransomware security incident • **When:** 9 am Tuesday • **Where:** A small U.S. health care clinic • **Why:** The incident happened because unethical hackers were able to access the company's systems using a phishing attack. After gaining access, the attackers launched their ransomware on the company's systems, encrypting critical files. The attackers' motivation appears to be financial because the ransom note they left demanded a large sum of money in exchange for the decryption key.
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings. - How many employees downloaded the ransomware? - How many emails were sent out? - How could the health care company prevent an incident like this from occurring again? - Should the company pay the ransom to retrieve the decryption key?

Date: 08/02/2026	**Entry: #2 - Activity: Investigate a suspicious file hash**
Description	An employee received an email containing a suspicious file. I'm investigating the hash of the file.
Tool(s) used	I used VirusTotal, an investigative tool that analyses files and URLs for malicious content, including viruses, worms, trojans, and more. It's a very helpful tool to use if you want to quickly check if an indicator of compromise, like a website or file, has been reported as malicious by others in the cybersecurity community, who

	contributed to the insightful metrics like the Community Score, Vendor Ratio and Security Vendors' analysis. The incident occurred in the **Detection and Analysis** phase. The scenario put me in the place of a security analyst at a SOC investigating a suspicious file hash. After the suspicious file was detected by the security systems in place, I had to perform a deeper analysis and investigation to determine if the alert signified a real threat.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who**: An unknown malicious actor • **What**: Phishing incident - An email sent to an employee contained a malicious file attachment with the SHA-256 file hash of 54e6ea47eb04634d3e87fd7787e2136ccfbcc80ade34f246a12cf93bab527f6b • **When**: At 1:20 p.m., an alert was sent to the organisation's SOC after the intrusion detection system detected the file • **Where**: Financial services company • **Why**: The employee downloaded the file attached to the phishing email, which was verified to be malicious. This malicious file has a type of malware attached to it called a Trojan.
Additional notes	- What was the threat actor's motive? - Did the malware affect any other systems? - How can this incident be prevented in the future? - Should we consider improving security awareness training so that employees are careful with what they click on?

Date: 22/02/2026	**Entry: #3 - Activity: Analyse your first packet**
Description	Analysing a network packet capture file containing traffic data related to a user connecting to an internet site.
Tool(s) used	I used Wireshark to analyse a packet capture file. Wireshark is a network protocol analyser that uses a graphical user interface. The value of Wireshark in cybersecurity is that it allows security analysts to capture and analyse network traffic. This can help in detecting and investigating malicious activity. During my use of Wireshark, I opened saved packet capture files, viewed high-level packet data, and used filters to inspect detailed packet data.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who:** Not applicable – no attacker identified in this activity • **What:** Network traffic analysis exercise • **Where**: Local analysis environment • **When:** Not specified • **Why:** To analyse packet data and understand network traffic behaviour
Additional notes	Wireshark is a very detailed network protocol analyser, which is why it's such a powerful tool for understanding network traffic.

Date: 22/02/2026	**Entry: #4 - Activity: Capture your first packet**
Description	Analysing a packet capture file

Tool(s) used	I used tcpdump to capture and analyse network traffic. Tcpdump is a network protocol analyser that's accessed using a CLI. Similar to Wireshark, the value of tcpdump in cybersecurity is that it allows security analysts to capture, filter and analyse network traffic.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who**: No specific threat actor was identified, as this activity focused on capturing network traffic rather than investigating a malicious incident • **What**: Network traffic was captured and analysed using tcpdump to observe how data packets are transmitted across a network. • **When**: The packet capture occurred during the activity session; no specific timestamp was required for this exercise. • **Where**: The activity took place within a controlled/local analysis environment where network traffic could be safely monitored. • **Why**: The purpose of this activity was to develop an understanding of how network traffic can be captured and analysed to support the detection and investigation of potential security incidents.
Additional notes	I preferred using the CLI interface compared to Wireshark's GUI because the interface was less overwhelming. The commands weren't too difficult to use, and I was able to get through tasks without struggling.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	**Entry:** Record the journal entry number.
Description	Provide a brief description about the journal entry.
Tool(s) used	List any cybersecurity tools that were used.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? • **What** happened? • **When** did the incident occur? • **Where** did the incident happen? • **Why** did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes:

Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?
Yes, I found the 'Activity: Explore signatures and logs with Suricata' quite challenging because it was a lot of content to take in at once, especially the different types of commands and outputs. However, I do believe that over time will become more comfortable with the commands and outputs, as I use them more.

Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course?
After taking this course, my understanding of incident detection and response has definitely evolved. At the beginning of the course, I had some basic understanding of what detection and response entailed, but I didn't fully understand the complexity involved. As I progressed through the course, I learned about the lifecycle of an incident; the importance of plans, processes, and people; and tools used. Overall, I feel that my understanding has changed, and I am equipped with more knowledge and understanding about incident detection and response.

Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?
VirusTotal was the tool I enjoyed the most because of its strong community-driven approach. It feels like you are part of a global network of cybersecurity professionals, as the platform brings together insights from multiple security vendors and users. I found it especially useful for quickly analysing file hashes and determining whether something is malicious, as it provides clear results in one place. Features like the community score and vendor analysis made it easier to understand how threats are identified, and overall, the tool felt both practical and relevant to real-world incident investigation.